Graphic Design

# Design on the Go

Summary Notes

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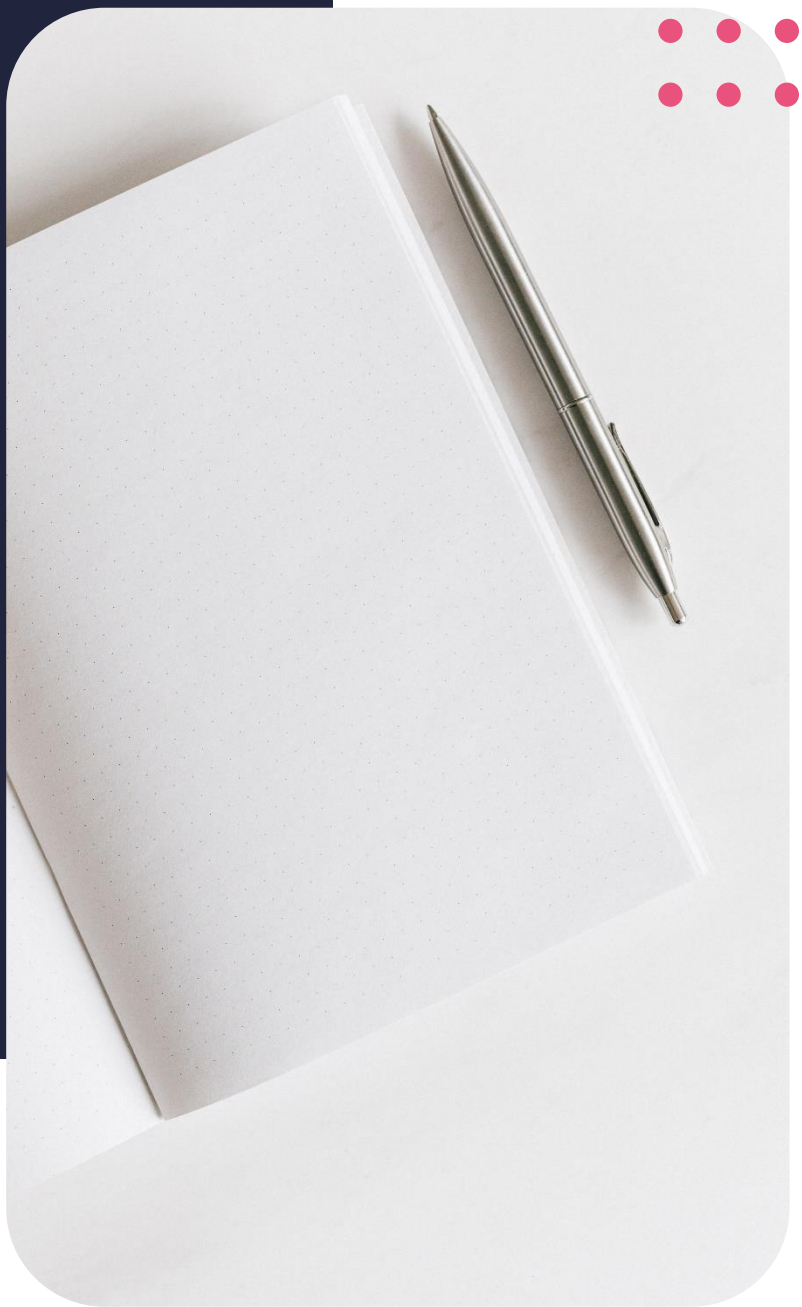


## Lesson outcomes

By the end of this lesson, you should be able to:

- Understand the advent of mobile applications
- List and identify mobile apps for graphic design
- Design with mobile apps

# Introduction

Even though technology has changed vastly, especially over the last decade or so, mobile applications are not yet where computers are, especially when it comes to creating custom designs. There are a variety of mobile apps that make it possible to create amazing looking designs however.

These applications work on the principle of having pre-set templates that can be adjusted accordingly. And even though these apps do not really count as claiming yourself to be a professional graphic designer, it is crucial to know about them and their features because, even graphic designers need to design on the go, when they don't have their computers with them.

Perhaps in the future, graphic design might change to be more mobile-based, but for the time being, a computer still allows you the most flexibility and control when it comes to graphic design and I personally, prefer a computer. I still believe you need a solid foundation, a thorough understanding of the elements & principles of design as well as experience to even consider yourself a professional, regardless of the medium you use.

Like it or hate it, graphic design is changing, and we need to adapt with the times!

Susan Kare, famous for her interface icons, typeface contributions and also one of the first employees of NeXT, the IT company established by Steve Jobs, stated that "good design's not about what medium you're working in. It's about thinking hard about what you want to do and what you have to work with before you start.

I will be showing you the use of design applications on mobile phones today. You might have heard of these applications before or not. Either way, one thing is certain: never underestimate the medium you're working on. You won't go to a bakery claiming they have the best oven that bakes the most amazing cakes, no, you would rather complement the baker, of course! The same principle applies to design – it's not the medium or application you use that makes a design successful, it is the designer!

# The advent of mobile applications

## The origin of mobile phones

Mobile apps have been around for a lot longer than we might think.  Not necessarily in the sense we understand an app to be but none the less, they have been around since 1993!

To understand where mobile apps fit into this whole picture, we need to look at some history.  I would like to start with the first mobile phone which was created by Motorola.

*The first mobile phone invented by Motorola*

This phone made the first call in 1973! It weighed a whopping 1,1kg – this is equivalent to 2,4 pounds! However, another decade had to pass before you could actually buy a mobile phone for a monstrous price of $4000!

## The origin of smartphones

The evolution of the cellular phone led to the invention of the smart phone in 1992 – the first smart phone was known as the Simon Personal Computer.  It was however only available commercially in 1994.

*The Simon Personal Computer, first smartphone*

What is the difference between a cellular phone and smart phone? The features that differentiated this device from mobile phones was the fact that it had a touch screen, could send and receive emails and faxes, and it had a notes and calendar function. The Simon Personal computer had a monochrome LCD display and its battery only lasted for one hour.

## What is a mobile app?

A mobile app or application is a software application designed to be used on small, wireless computing devices like smartphones and tablets including iOS and Android.  It is thus a computer software or program in a compact format rather considering the demands and constraints of said devices.

Understanding that it works with the device's constraints in mind, it is then obvious that mobile apps are not as functional as their computer equivalents.

Mobile apps do however offer amazing features that computers might not offer due to the fact that they are compatible with mobile devices.  Thinking specifically with regards to your GPS on your phone.  This application is able to take you anywhere you desire with live updates of roadblocks or speed cameras.  At the end, the aim of a mobile app is to make the lives more convenient and easier for its operator.

## Did you know?

Did you know that your mobile phone has more computing power than the computer used for the Apollo 11 moon landing?

The Apollo computer had a miniscule 32 768 bits of RAM memory! If this does not make much sense to you, let's compare it to your phone. The typical mobile phone today has around 4gb of ram which is roughly 34 billion RAM compared to the 32 000 RAM from Apollo 11's computer! Even comparing the Apollo 11 computer to a current classic calculator, our classic calculator is 140 times faster!

# Mobile vs Desktop

Apple launched its App store back in 2008 and we did not realise how ground-breaking this would be. Several years later, anyone, whether you have an iPhone or Android phone can access the App or Play store respectively and download almost any app imaginable. What ever you can think of, there will probably be an app for that.

Now considering that mobile apps are here to stay, desktop software is far from dead and for good reason.

## Mobile devices and apps

Let's look at the features that differentiate a mobile app from desktop software, and although it feels almost impossible to live without mobile apps, they do have their shortcomings.

| Good | Not so good |
|---|---|
| • Firstly, it is extremely easy to use. I don't think I even need to elaborate on this – if you have used apps before, you will know what I mean. They are simply intuitive, and this makes them quick to get used to.<br>• If you have an internet connection, you can download an app wherever you are<br>• Mobile apps are normally free to use, but you might get in-app purchases | • Apps are also one-purpose. Meaning that you have an app for every task that you would like to do. This means that you will probably install a lot of apps for all your tasks<br>• Due to mobile phones and tables small scale, apps have limited functionality<br>• Even though mobile phones and tables processors are improving, they are still weak in comparison to desktop computers<br>• Storage space on your phone is also not as vast as on your computer<br>• When a desktop software or website is converted to a mobile app, it is difficult to replicate the user interaction to match that of the desktop software or website. |

On the other hand, desktop software has been around for a lot longer.

| Good | Not so good |
|---|---|
| • The fact that you do not necessarily need to have internet access to make a desktop app work is a massive advantage.<br>• Computers have greater functionality with the software installed on them.<br>• Computers in general have faster processors than mobile devices like smart phones and tablets, which makes them powerful machines.<br>• Desktop computers have more storage space than your mobile phone.<br>• It is relatively easy to upgrade your hardware on a computer – you simply add more RAM or a bigger hard drive whereas with mobile devices, you need to upgrade to a later model.<br>• Computers are quite durable and lasts a lot longer than mobile devices | • The problem with computers is that most software is not free, however, there are plenty of open source software that has amazing capabilities but in general the good stuff aren't free.<br>• Computers, whether it be a desktop or laptop are bulkier and thus you can't always carry them around with you – this limits their range of accessibility.<br>• I do believe in future this will change, I mean, it is currently changing, and today's mobile phones are a lot more advanced than 5 years ago. But for the time being, desktop software just allows you more flexibility and functionality when it comes to graphic design specifically |

# Mobile apps for graphic design

Now, before you accuse me of anything, I want you to look at these applications with an open mind. Reiterating Susan Kare's quote – it's not about the medium but about the thought and effort behind the project. I myself was quite against these applications because I thought you don't need to think much to create a design but using the knowledge, skills and foundation you have learnt and build up in this course up to know, I am sure you will be able to make good judgement about the designs you are creating. Also, having these applications to your access, you should be a lot better than your cousin who downloaded these apps but don't have a design background.

Having a better understanding on mobile apps, their role and limitations, we will investigate some useful apps that graphic designers can make use of aiding them in making life slightly easier.

## Mobile apps for graphic design

I have hand picked the following apps but am sure that there are other amazing and useful apps that make our lives as graphic designers a lot easier. The problem is that there are so many apps to choose from, so where do you start? If you have any other interesting apps that you make use of, then by all means, keep using them!

Canva is the first app we will look at today.

*Canva*

You can select a template for which ever reason, whether you are creating an Instagram story or post, a logo, a flyer, video… basically any design you can think of. But due to the fact that it is template based, makes your designs slightly more generic looking. You can however create a nice design on the desktop version and you will still be able to access it

on your smart phone. Also, you can actually start from scratch and open a blank document.  Canva is free to use but have paid-for features.

Adobe Capture is handy for when you want a specific colour scheme or palette form a photograph in your phone's library or of a photo that you are about to take.

*Adobe Capture*

What is amazing about this app is that it syncs to all your other adobe applications.  It has the ability to identify fonts, create looks, colour schemes, patterns and even brushes that can be used in for example Adobe Photoshop.

Spark Post, is also an Adobe product and does the same thing as Canva – you have a variety of templates to choose from in order to create amazing designs ranging from Facebook posts, invitation cards, videos and what ever you can think of.

*Adobe Spark Post*

A lot of the templates are free, but you also get paid-for templates.  As with Canva, you can also create a design from scratch here.

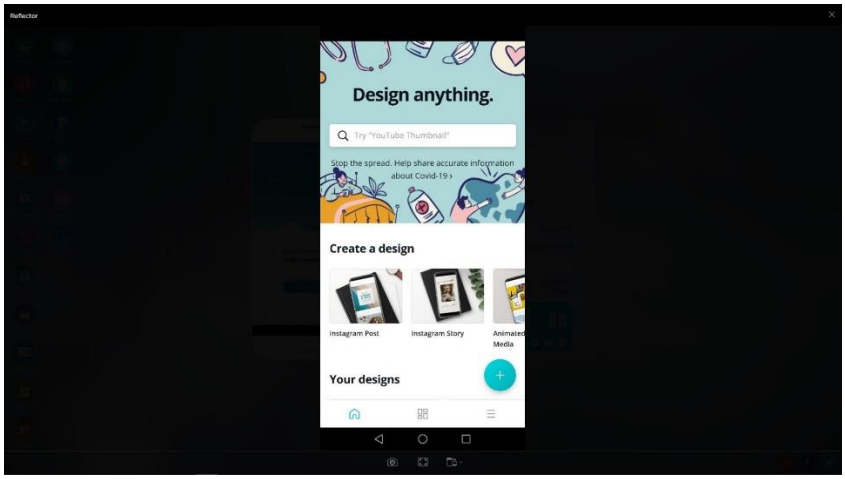
Resplash is just a really cool app version of the already popular Unsplash website where you are able to access millions of amazing quality stock images for your designs.

*Resplash*

You are also able to access stock photos from Canva and Spark Post but you will never have enough options when it comes to accessing good quality photos. Most of the images I used in this lesson's design I got from Unsplash.

## Canva demo *(please refer to video lesson)*

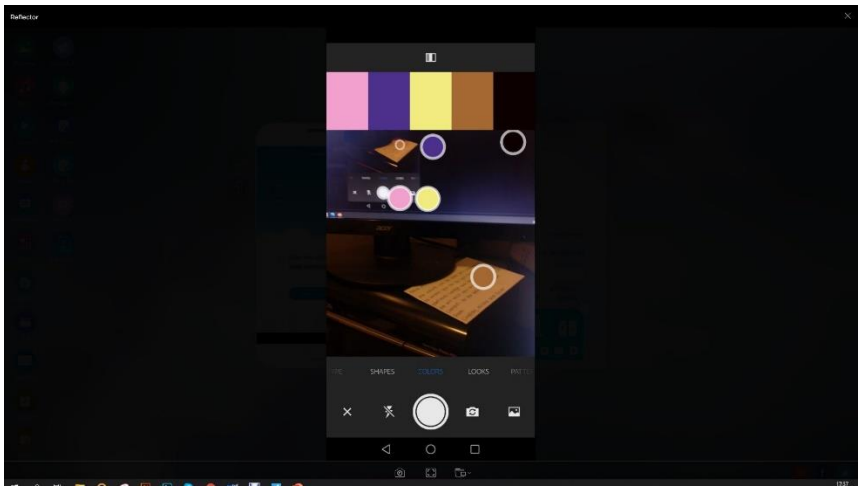
I will give you a demo of each of the 4 applications I introduced to you earlier. Note that I won't do a design in each application but will mainly introduce you to the interface of these apps. Since they are intuitive and extremely user friendly, I don't think you will have an issue when it comes to creating awesome designs with these apps. Lets start with Canva… which is an all-in-one graphic design app allowing you to create almost any type of design, from a Facebook post, to a video.




*Demo in Canva*

## Adobe Capture demo *(please refer to video lesson)*

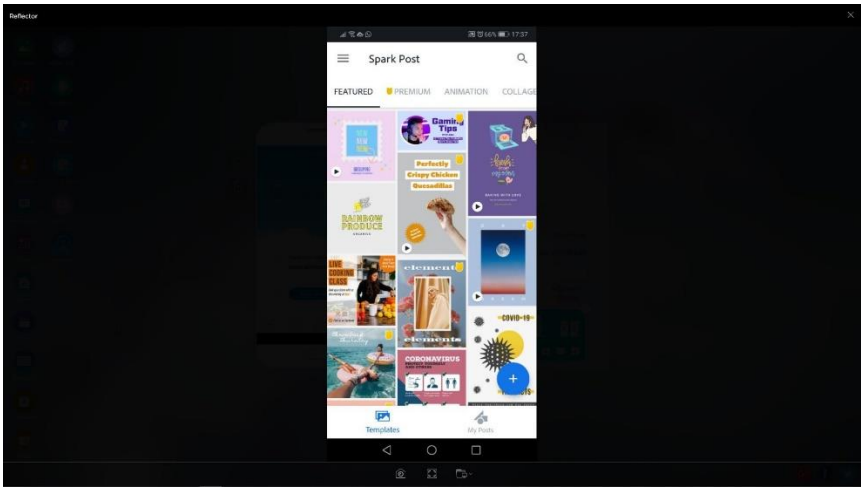
Imagine that you can use your phones camera to see vectors, patterns and even fonts. Adobe capture allows you to create vectors, colour palettes, patterns, 3D material from your camera and photos and you can even import them into your favourite Adobe desktop software!



*Adobe Capture demo*

## Spark Post demo *(please refer to video lesson)*

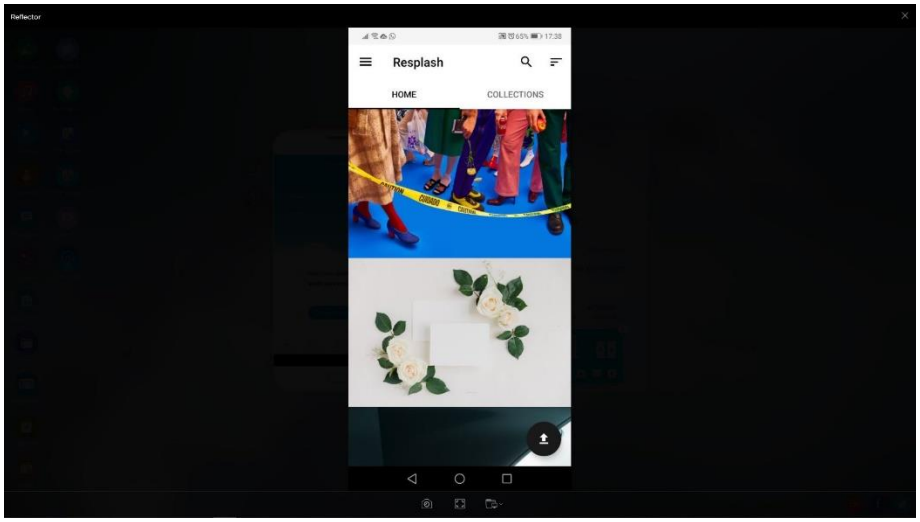
Like Canva, Adobe Spark Post makes mainly use of professionally designed templates that you can tweak and adjust to suit your specific needs.  You will be able to create animated video posts, invitations, photo collages, memes, flyers and a whole lot more.




*Spark Post demo*

## Resplash demo *(please refer to video lesson)*

Resplash offers its user access to millions of free professionally taken photographs from around the world.  Thank you to all these photographers allowing use to make use of your work!  By the way, most of the stock images in this lesson is from Unsplash, which is the web version of Resplash.




*Resplash demo*

# Conclusion

Although apps are limited in comparison to desktop or web-based software, there is a space and a place for them in our current society and lifestyle.  They literally make life slightly easier for us and seeing as they won't disappear in the near future, we might as well utilise these features.

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